A CONFERENCE WORKBOOK FOR MSP LEADERS

RETURN ON ATTENDANCE

Because SWAG doesn't count as ROI

THIS WORKBOOK BELONGS TO

_____

MSP CULTURE

The MSP Culture guide to conference ROI

mspculture.com

START HERE

How to use this workbook

Five sections, worked over about a month. Most of the value is in the parts that happen away from the show floor.

TWO WEEKS OUT	01 **Before You Go** Top 3 problems, the one big problem, and vendor meetings booked.	pp. 03–04
ONE WEEK OUT	02 **Build Your Agenda** A Love, a Need and a Want session, plus the people you want to meet.	p. 05
AT THE SHOW	03 **At the Show** Session notes, a vendor and people log, and an ideas parking lot. Print extra note pages.	pp. 06–08
WHEELS UP	04 **The Flight Home** Three takeaways and a 90-day plan for one of them.	p. 09
ONE WEEK AFTER	05 **The ROI Call** Cost against value, a score, and a decision on next year.	pp. 10–11

NAME

COMPANY

CONFERENCE

DATES & CITY

WHO ELSE IS GOING FROM OUR TEAM

Three rules

1. Everything traces back to one of your top 3 problems. If it doesn't, it's a want, and that's fine once.
2. Write it down within the hour, or it didn't happen.
3. Decide on next year one week after you land, while it's still honest.

What are we actually trying to solve?

Book 60 minutes with your team at least a week before you fly. Whoever goes to the show is working on the company's problems, not just their own.

HUDDLE DATE

WHO WAS IN THE ROOM

Our top 3 problems as a company

Business problems, not tool wish lists. "Margins on project work are shrinking" beats "we want a new PSA."

1

THE PROBLEM

WHO OWNS IT

SOLVED LOOKS LIKE

2

THE PROBLEM

WHO OWNS IT

SOLVED LOOKS LIKE

3

THE PROBLEM

WHO OWNS IT

SOLVED LOOKS LIKE

If we could solve one big problem on this trip, it would be:

WHY THIS ONE, AND WHY NOW?

Which vendors are worth your time?

Existing partners get a seat because you already pay them. A vendor you're exploring gets a seat only if it maps to one of your top 3 problems. Book meetings before you land; the good slots go fast.

WHAT CAN WE SIGN AT THE SHOW? ($) _____

WHO CAN APPROVE IT _____

VENDOR	EXISTING / EXPLORING	PROB. #	WHAT WE NEED FROM THEM	BOOKED
	E / X			☐
	E / X			☐
	E / X			☐
	E / X			☐
	E / X			☐
	E / X			☐
	E / X			☐
	E / X			☐

Ask every vendor these five

1. What are your best partners doing with your product that we aren't?
2. What ships in the next two quarters that changes how we'd use you?
3. Which integrations do partners actually run, versus what's on the slide?
4. Who owns our account after the show? Name and email, not a portal.
5. What can you offer this week that you can't next month?

Exploring a replacement? Ask for three references at partners your size, and call them before you sign anything.

Love it. Need it. Want it.

Pick at least one session in each category. Every NEED should trace back to one of your top 3 problems. If a session is a dud fifteen minutes in, walk out; the hallway is a session too.

LOVE

Your craft. The topic that fires you up and sends you home with energy.

SESSION	DAY & TIME	ROOM	PROB. #

NEED

Ties directly to a top 3 problem. This is what the company is paying for.

SESSION	DAY & TIME	ROOM	PROB. #

WANT

Outside your lane. The thing you're curious about but can't justify yet.

SESSION	DAY & TIME	ROOM	PROB. #

People I want to meet

NAME	COMPANY	WHY THEM

OPEN BLOCKS I'M PROTECTING FOR THE HALLWAY

What did you just learn?

Print as many of these as you need. Fill in the shaded row before you leave the room; it's the only part you'll actually use later.

SESSION _____ **SPEAKER** _____

CIRCLE ONE **LOVE** **NEED** **WANT** _____ **TIES TO PROBLEM #** _____

NOTES

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

BIG IDEA	STEAL THIS	FOLLOW UP WITH

SESSION _____ **SPEAKER** _____

CIRCLE ONE **LOVE** **NEED** **WANT** _____ **TIES TO PROBLEM #** _____

NOTES

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

BIG IDEA	STEAL THIS	FOLLOW UP WITH

03 · AT THE SHOW · VENDOR & PEOPLE LOG

Who did you talk to?

Write it down within the hour. By day three every booth blurs together, and the follow-up you promised in the expo hall is the one that slips.

Vendors

VENDOR & REP	WHAT WE LEARNED	OFFER / PRICING	NEXT STEP & DATE

People

NAME & COMPANY	WHY THEY MATTER	WHAT I PROMISED	BY WHEN

03 · AT THE SHOW · IDEAS PARKING LOT

Park it here. Sort it later.

Anything that sparks in a session, the hallway, or the after-party. No filtering at the show. On the flight home, tick the ones worth keeping.

IDEA	PROB. #	KEEP?
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐

What are you actually bringing back?

Do this before wheels down; once you land, the inbox wins. Flip through your session notes and the parking lot, then commit.

Three big takeaways

1

2

3

THE ONE WE PUSH

1 2 3

Circle one. Just one.

WHY THIS ONE?

Three moves in the next 90 days

#	ACTION	OWNER	DUE	DONE LOOKS LIKE
1				
2				
3				

MONDAY MORNING

Who hears about this first

Team debrief date

☐ Every follow-up I promised, plus day 30, 60 and 90 check-ins, is on my calendar.

Was it worth it?

Wait one week: long enough for the jet lag to clear, short enough that the sessions are still real. Six months from now you'll remember how fun the party was, not how thin the content was. Decide on next year now.

What it cost

Registration	$
Airfare	$
Hotel	$
Meals & incidentals	$
Time away: ____ hrs × $____	$
Other	$
Total cost	**$**

What it returned

Show deals & discounts	$
Tools cut or replaced (annual)	$
Hours saved per year × rate	$
Pipeline & referrals	$
Top 3 problem progress	$
Other	$
Total value	**$**

Only count what you can point to. "Great networking" is not a number.

Value − cost = $ _____

The gut-check scorecard

1 = NO · 5 = ABSOLUTELY

We moved a top 3 problem forward	1	2	3	4	5
The NEED sessions delivered	1	2	3	4	5
Vendor time paid off	1	2	3	4	5
I met people worth knowing	1	2	3	4	5
I came back with energy, not just swag	1	2	3	4	5
The 90-day plan is actually moving	1	2	3	4	5

SCORE _____ / 30

Make the call.

Use the score as a guide, not a verdict. 24 to 30: go back. 15 to 23: go back, but change something. Under 15: skip it and spend the budget where it will move a top 3 problem.

☐ **Go back, same plan**

It paid off. Register at early-bird pricing and run this workbook again, starting with a new team huddle.

☐ **Go back, but change it**

Fewer people or different people. A different track. Speak, sponsor or host a meetup instead of only attending.

What changes

_____

☐ **Skip it**

Not every show earns a repeat. Put the money where it moves a top 3 problem.

Where the budget goes instead

_____

WHY, IN ONE SENTENCE

_____

_____

EARLY-BIRD DEADLINE

_____

BUDGET OWNER

_____

WHO GOES NEXT YEAR

_____

☐ Registration reminder is on the calendar

DECIDED BY

_____

DATE

_____

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